

Enforce Your New Nature: Pray

Open to Romans 8, where we left off around verse 9.

Romans 8:8 says:

"So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God."

Then verse 9 is very clear:

"But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you.
Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."

Romans 7 is an unregenerated man, particularly a Jew, who received the law and could not keep it. When we talk about the righteousness of the law, we are talking about the Ten Commandments, which describe the nature of God. An unregenerated man could not keep them.

That is why Paul said:

"I had not known sin, but by the law:
for I had not known lust, except the law had said, Thou shalt not covet."

A spiritually dead man does not know he is dead until someone comes along and tells him. You were born spiritually dead, and that is all you have ever been. How would you know anything else?

First Corinthians says:

"What man knoweth the things of a man, save the spirit of man which is in him?"

Since spiritually dead man can only know by the spirit of man in him, what can he know except the things of spiritual death? He has no way to know anything else. But what man knows the things of God except the born-again spirit that is now in him?

Romans 7 is the unregenerated man who received the law and could not keep it. The change came in Romans 8:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

Every time Paul says "not after the flesh, but after the Spirit," the phrase "after the flesh" points back to Romans 7, the unregenerated man who received the law and could not keep it. He was forced to walk after the flesh. He had no choice. God said, "Thou shalt not covet." He tried to stop and could not.

Romans 8 says there is therefore now no condemnation to those in Christ Jesus who walk not after the flesh but after the spirit. The spirit you walk after now is that new nature that has set you free from sin, so nothing can force you into sin. It has freed you from that condemnation.

There is not enough power anywhere to force us into sin if we do not want to sin. You may think there is, but there is not. Resist it, and you will find out it does not have enough power to make you sin.

Remember, Jesus was thirty years old before He received the baptism of the Holy Spirit. When you were baptized in the Holy Ghost, Jesus said:

"Ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you."

Jesus did not walk in miracle power until He was baptized in the Holy Ghost. Yet He walked thirty years free from sin.

Why was He free from sin? Because He was the first Man in four thousand years to be born spiritually alive, free from sin.

It is your new nature that freed you from sin. That is what the Holy Ghost has to work with: your new nature.

That is why I am so hard on justifying failures. As long as you justify failure, sin, or anything habitual, you take away from the Holy Ghost what He needs from you to set you free. If you let Him get behind your new nature and enforce everything you have been made, that is when you get free.

If you justify your failure, the Holy Ghost has nothing to work with.

In Romans 8, Paul acts as a lawyer. He stands between Romans 7 and Romans 8, between the two covenants, and argues your freedom under the New Covenant.

Any time he uses terminology like "after the flesh," he is talking about the man under spiritual death, who received the law and could not keep it. The man now in the spirit has been born again. Sin has no more dominion over him, so he is free.

Agree with that new nature, and the Holy Ghost has something to work with.

Romans 8:2-4 says:

"For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus hath made me free from the law of sin and death.

For what the law could not do, in that it was weak through the flesh,
God sending his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh,
and for sin, condemned sin in the flesh:
That the righteousness of the law might be fulfilled in us,
who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit."

The right standing of the law, the Ten Commandments, "Thou shalt not," can finally be fulfilled in us who walk not after the flesh but after the spirit.

Romans 8:5 says:

"For they that are after the flesh do mind the things of the flesh;
but they that are after the Spirit the things of the Spirit."

In Romans 7, Paul said, "With my mind I wanted to serve God, but I see another law working in my members, bringing me into captivity to the law of sin." The mind of the unregenerated man is a prisoner to sin and death in his body. Even if he resists for a while, he always falls back in because that is what he is.

If you are born a mule, you are going to come out of the starting gate as a mule. Your owner can crop your ears, trim your tail, and say, "Stop being a mule because I want to win money off you in races," but when the gate opens, you are still a mule.

They that are after the flesh mind the things of the flesh. Their mind is continually brought back under subjection to the law of sin and death.

But those who are after the spirit have their mind brought under subjection to a new law, the law of life. There is no power in their body that can force their mind to serve sin anymore.

If you are doing what you know you are free from, then know this: He set you free back there. When you start agreeing with your freedom, the Holy Ghost says, "Finally. I have been waiting for you to stop accepting failure."

One way to exercise faith and quit failure is to start praying in tongues a lot.

How many pray in tongues a lot? Hallelujah. No wonder you are looking at me like you are free.

Fasting, praying, confessing the Word, and worshiping, when balanced together, make you some kind of believer. I feel like some kind of believer. I thank God for His peace. I am so happy I am bouncing on my toes.

Does anybody around you have anything to do with your joy and walk with God? No. Nobody can. I carry my victory with me.

If somebody can destroy your life by being ugly to you, then you are an easy takeout. When they are done with you, you breathe deep and say, "I am sure glad they are out of my life. I will do better now." No, you will not, because the devil will send another one.

Someone says, "I am going to get away from this church. My circumstances will change." Do you not understand yet that your victory is within? If you are the one defeated, when you get to another church, you will still be there.

Have you ever run into yourself?

When I started praying a lot, the person I ended up hating the worst was me. I used to think other people were my problem. The further I got into God, the more I found that nobody had anything to do with my walk. Not even the devil.

Who can separate us from the love of God in Christ? Paul became thoroughly convinced, and you have seen the way he lived. If he became convinced, the best thing you can do is become convinced before you get there.

Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ Jesus: not height, depth, things to come, things above or beneath, and especially not another person.

I remember when I began responding to the new nature in me. One day I thought, I cannot live on this edge anymore, fighting to go to church, fighting to do this and that. There must be something I can do, because inside there was a nagging to serve Him. I did not know exactly what it was. It was my new nature working on me to surrender.

I went to church that Sunday morning. You have to understand this church. If you missed a service, you were backslidden. If you put pants on, you were backslidden. If you wore jewelry, you were backslidden.

I made up my mind I was going to give in to whatever was working in me. I did not care if I felt like it. I decided to follow it.

Some families came up to get saved, so I went up and knelt behind them and started praying for them. It was the first time I had ever done anything like that.

The pastor came over and said, "Are these relatives of yours?"

I said, "No."

"Friends?"

"I do not know them."

"What are you doing up here praying?"

I did not know that either, but I had made up my mind that I wanted to follow what was inside.

Up until that time, I had stammering lips. Prayer warriors would grab me and try to pray me through, and I would shake and stammer. But when I made up my mind to walk after that new nature inside, though I did not know that was what I was doing, something happened.

I was at home worshiping God and thanking Him for filling and saving me. Something came into my arms and went down my arms. It was hot and numb, and it got into my chest. When it did, I got weak and fell over. When I hit my back on the floor, it knocked the wind out of me. When the wind came out, you should have heard the language that came out with it.

I felt nothing. I went to the end of a tunnel, and I do not know how long I was there. I do know it was the next morning when I finally came out of it. Tongues flowed so hard I could hardly catch my breath.

I have never been back. Hunger absolutely consumed me.

I was in Oregon with three little children, David, Steve, and Bill. They were very small. The hunger to go full time was so strong in me I was consumed with it. As a result of a visitation, I quit my job.

Nobody would come hear me. I had nowhere to preach because I had never really preached before. I did not know how to get started.

So at five or six o'clock every morning, I went to the prayer closet. I did not know about praying in tongues. In fact, the legalistic teaching I had made me think the praying I was doing might be out of order, because many taught you could only pray in tongues when there was a heavy anointing on you.

The only thing I knew was that I had a lot of hours ahead of me, and I had better do something. I did not know how to pray, so I stayed in the room and prayed in tongues.

We got about \$600 behind in three months. I was charging bills at the local grocery store, the mill supply store. When I worked at the mill, you could have an account there. The man kept looking at me and finally asked, "Where do you work?"

I had resigned my job to take a pastorate of about six or seven people. He kept looking at me strangely while the bill grew. To me, \$200 was big.

Near the end of those three months, somebody introduced me to Kenneth Hagin. I started learning how to believe, but I continued praying in the closet six to eight hours a day.

I bought an old Wilcox tape recorder with a plaid cover and listened to Hagin's reel-to-reel tapes at night:

"When I was a young Baptist boy on the bed of affliction, God healed my body."

After about three months of praying in the Holy Ghost, revelation began to kick in. Verses I had looked at all my life suddenly were picked up and explained to me by something on the inside. The mysteries I had been praying began coming alive in just three months.

People keep asking me who trained me. I have to keep going back to the Holy Ghost. I was in obscurity in Oregon. I had nobody else.

I had left my mill job, and the men told me, "We will hold your job for you. Any time you want to come back, we will have a job."

I said, "I will not be back."

Six months later, I had a brand-new Volkswagen van, paid for. I drove it onto the mill property, where cars were not allowed, and blocked the break-shack door so the men could not come out.

I said, "Come out and see my failure. You all said I would be back. Come out and look at my failure. Smell the upholstery. And do you want to know something else? It is paid for."

Before that, about three months into prayer, I had been catching for a man in meetings. I would drive fifty miles one way just to get into a meeting where God moved. I would stay until two in the morning, listening to him talk about miracles, then get up and work ten hours the next day. I did that for one or two weeks at a time because I was hungry.

Then this man wanted me to catch for him in Salem, which was about 150 miles from Oakridge. I had run out of everything. A woman asked, "Would you drive me to Salem?"

I thought, There is my ride.

So we went. Afterward, a man walked up to me and handed me a piece of paper. I opened it and looked at it because nobody handed me checks. As far as I knew, it was a note.

My head was pounding with a blinding headache. I thought it said \$7.86. Then my eyes focused. It was \$786.

I thought I had died right there. I put it in my coat pocket and patted it every fifteen minutes. I rubbed it and would not say anything to anybody because I was afraid it would disappear.

That night I showed Rosalie the check. She got excited, but my head was pounding and all I wanted to do was sleep.

The next day, out of gas, I walked to the bank. I was in such shock I almost forgot how to sign my name. I asked, "Can I write checks on this right away?"

She said, "Yes, you can, son."

I walked from the bank to the church. I will never forget that day. I went into my prayer closet like usual, got down, and started praying. The spirit of worship came on me, and I worshiped God. I thought I had died and gone to heaven.

I said, "God, I would have done anything to do this. I would have worked the rest of my life anywhere You sent me and done this. I wanted to preach so badly. I wanted to pray so badly."

Now I was in the closet with provision. "The rest of my life I am going to get to do exactly what I would have given anything to do. I am going to come down and spend days with You, walk out and tell people about it, and get paid?"

That drive has been in me from that day to this. I do not care if I preach eighteen times a month, where I sleep, or whether I preach twenty-five times a month. Nothing in me is burning out.

The lamp of the righteous burns brighter and brighter. Nothing is wearing out. I feel better than I did when I was eighteen. I had headaches all the time then. I have nothing now.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

Romans 8:5 says:

"They that are after the Spirit [mind] the things of the Spirit."

Their thoughts and reasonings are now dominated and influenced by the new nature.

Then Paul goes back to the spiritually dead man in verse 6:

"For to be carnally minded is death;
but to be spiritually minded is life and peace."

When that new nature, whose root is agape, the love and nature of God, takes ascendancy over the mind, your mind rests in peace.

If you have been sold short of anything, do not be sold short of peace. I would esteem peace as the greatest treasure of this life.

There is a walk after the flesh versus the spirit for a born-again man, but that is not what Paul is talking about in this chapter. In Romans 8, he is contrasting the unregenerated man under law with the born-again man under the new nature.

Romans 8:7-9 says:

"Because the carnal mind is enmity against God:
for it is not subject to the law of God, neither indeed can be.
So then they that are in the flesh cannot please God.
But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit, if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you.
Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."

The carnal mind is the enemy of God. It is not subject to the law of God and cannot be. But now that you are born again, the right standing of the law can finally be fulfilled in you because you walk not after the flesh but after the spirit.

Romans 8:9 says:

"But ye are not in the flesh, but in the Spirit,
if so be that the Spirit of God dwell in you.
Now if any man have not the Spirit of Christ, he is none of his."

The Spirit of Christ here is not the Holy Ghost. The Holy Ghost is the third Person in the Godhead. He is His own Person, not the Spirit of Christ. Jehovah is not the Spirit of Christ. Jesus in His humanity is a Person, and you are not baptized into Jesus' own human spirit.

The Holy Ghost is the Person of the Godhead who does the work of regeneration.

So what is the Spirit of Christ? John 5 says that as the Father has life in Himself, He gave to the Son to have life in Himself, and the Son gave you power to become a son of God. He has given you life to have life within yourself.

The Spirit of Christ refers to the life that was in Jesus' human spirit. He was born spiritually alive, died spiritually, and was quickened from death to life. When we identified with Him, the same law of the Spirit of life that brought Him from death to life brought us from death to life.

It is not Jesus' own human spirit inside me. It is my own human spirit that went from death to life because of the law of the Spirit of life. I used to have the spirit of Adam. I did not have Adam's spirit, but I inherited spiritual death from him. I had the spirit of this world.

I do not have that anymore. The body of sin has been destroyed. I have the Spirit of Christ, the same life He rose from the dead with, in my own human spirit.

Do not try to make me sin. I will get mad.

Romans 8:10 says:

"And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin;
but the Spirit is life because of righteousness."

Positionally, the body has been declared dead because of sin, waiting on a resurrected body. It does not have the power to rule over you anymore.

Romans 8:11 says:

"But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you,
he that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by his Spirit
that dwelleth in you."

Why would Paul be talking about the new birth in the verses before this and then suddenly change subjects in verse 11? This is hard for traditional minds to swallow, but if you want to be free, listen.

In verse 11 he is still talking about your born-again, regenerated spirit.

Romans 8:12-13 says:

"Therefore, brethren, we are debtors, not to the flesh, to live after the flesh.
For if ye live after the flesh, ye shall die:
but if ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live."

The Holy Ghost does a work in you. Later, in verse 26, Paul talks about Him helping your weaknesses. But if you did not have the born-again nature inside you, the Holy Spirit would have nothing to work with.

When Paul says, "If ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body," he is talking about bringing your flesh under subjection to the new nature that says you are free from sin.

Romans 8:14 says:

"For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God."

He is not primarily talking about whether you should go to a neighboring town. He is talking about a man whose sin nature has been removed, who has been born again, and whose mind is now being brought under subjection to the new nature instead of the law of sin and death. As many as are led by that new nature are sons of God because they are no longer under the dominion of sin.

Romans 8:15 says:

"For ye have not received the spirit of bondage again to fear;
but ye have received the Spirit of adoption, whereby we cry, Abba, Father."

The spirit of bondage again to fear was the spiritual death inherited from Adam, especially as it operated in the Jew who received the law and could not keep it. Every time he tried, the law brought him into bondage and fear again.

Now that you have been born again, you do not have that spirit anymore. You have received the spirit of adoption. God took out your sin nature, gave you His nature, and called you His son.

Then Romans 8:16 finally mentions the Holy Spirit:

"The Spirit itself beareth witness with our spirit, that we are the children of God."

The next time He is mentioned is Romans 8:26:

"Likewise the Spirit also helpeth our infirmities:
for we know not what we should pray for as we ought:
but the Spirit itself maketh intercession for us with groanings which cannot be uttered."

Why does Paul say the Spirit "also" helps? Because something else has already set us free: the new nature. Now God sends the third Person of the Godhead to help our weaknesses.

It took two Persons of the Godhead to redeem you: One to pay the price, and One to come help every weakness left over in your life after you were born again.

The Holy Spirit says, "Step aside. You do not know how to pray as you ought. Let Me pray mysteries out. You do not even know the plan of God for your life."

He steps in with groanings that cannot be uttered. He communicates to God, and the only thing on His mind is helping your weaknesses. Now He has something to work with: a new nature.

He creates hours of prayer inside you. All you have to do is lend Him your authority, because you have authority on this earth. If He passes the prayer through your authority, the other two members of the Godhead receive the tongue He is preparing for your life and answer it.

It comes back in several ways: the plan of God opening up to you, understanding of mysteries, and strength in areas where you are weak. Anything defeating you, He intends to build you above it.

You are so slow you may not know who you are. That is all right. He is the One doing the praying. All you need is enough faith to let that new language roll out.

If I had a problem, I would pray every time somebody who would not understand was not looking.

Someone says, "Did you say something?"

Not to you, I did not.

I prayed so much one time that I went to the bank to cash a check. The teller asked, "Who do I make this..." and I was so caught up that tongues came out. I said, "I beg your pardon. I speak another language."

I have preached in thirteen different languages now: French, Arabic, Greek, Russian, Spanish, and others. Did I understand what I said? No. They had to tell me.

That is all right. Jesus has ridden a donkey before. The donkey did not understand either. Jesus could say, "Calm down, donkey. They are not waving those palm branches at you."

I am just the donkey He rode in on. If He wants to preach a whole night's message through me and leave me out of it, I do not care.

Practice praying in tongues enough, and that avenue will become so familiar and open to the Spirit of God that He will be able to create any kind of language for any need and send it through you.

Go back to John 1.

John 1:1-4 says:

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.
The same was in the beginning with God.
All things were made by him; and without him was not any thing made that was made.
In him was life; and the life was the light of men."

Before anything had a beginning, the Logos, whom we now know as Jesus, stood face to face and coequal with the other two members of the Godhead. Verse 3 isolates His role in creation. All things were made by Him.

Then verse 4 switches from His role as Creator to Redeemer:

"In him was life; and the life was the light of men."

The life in Him was that He was the first Man in four thousand years to be born spiritually alive. That life in His human spirit was the light of men. Soon you would be quickened with the same life. When you were, you received God's nature and could understand Him.

John 1:5 says:

"And the light shineth in darkness; and the darkness comprehended it not."

For four thousand years, every man had been born spiritually dead. Not since Adam and Eve's light went out had one person been born spiritually alive on this planet. That was the darkness: the spiritual death of the human race.

There was one soul candle, one spiritually alive Man, in the entire mass of humanity. One candle burned in all that darkness. His life would soon be extinguished, only to come alive again with you, and His life would become your light.

Hallelujah.

Go to First John 5:8:

"And there are three that bear witness in earth,
the Spirit, and the water, and the blood:
and these three agree in one."

These three bear witness to who Jesus is. First, the spirit. The "spirit" there is talking about His human spirit. In Him was life. He was the first spiritually alive human spirit in four thousand years, one single candle alive on this earth. That bore witness.

Second, the water. He had to be born into this earth through the birth canal.

Third, the blood. He had to come according to the promise, through Abraham's seed, the bloodline.

These three bear witness that He is the Christ. He was born spiritually alive, born into the human race through birth, and born of the promised bloodline, the Jewish line.

These three bear witness on earth, the spirit, the water, and the blood, that He indeed is the Christ.

Hallelujah.